



FAMILY COURT DATA REPORT · STATE SERIES · NO. 27

MONTANA

WHAT FAMILIES ARE REPORTING.

Pulled from the Family Rights Registry — the first cross-state dataset on what pro se parents are actually experiencing inside Montana's family courts and child-welfare system.

32

MONTANA FAMILIES ON RECORD · 44
CHILDREN IMPACTED · 36 MONTHS
MEDIAN MONTHS LOST OF PARENTING
TIME

REPORT GENERATED
APRIL 26, 2026

COUNTIES REPRESENTED
9 OF 56

COMPILED BY
MEG · STANDWITHMEG.COM

THE HEADLINE NUMBERS

MONTANA AT A GLANCE.

Across 32 Montana families reporting through the Family Rights Registry, the patterns are consistent: long durations in court, serious financial loss, and a disproportionate number of parents going unrepresented because they ran out of money fighting.

CHILDREN IMPACTED 44 32 of 32 families reported child counts	MEDIAN ATTORNEY FEES \$11,500 per reporting family	MEDIAN MONTHS LOST 36 of parenting time	WENT PRO SE 62.5% 43.8% after running out of money
SUBMISSIONS 32	AVG CHILDREN / FAMILY 1.4	FAMILIES REPORTING CHILDREN 32 of 32	COUNTIES REPRESENTED 9

WHY THIS REPORT EXISTS.

On January 29, 2024, I lost custody of all five of my children.

- NO TRIAL.
- NO QUESTIONING.
- NO SUBSTANTIATED ABUSE.

It took only a signature on an ex parte emergency order to erase a mother. I refused to disappear. I fought back, and built the Family Rights Registry so Montana families — and families in every state — would stop being invisible to the data. This report is their record.

— MEG · [STANDWITHMEG.COM](https://standwithmeg.com)

02 THE COST OF MONTANA FAMILY COURT

Legal fees are the largest reported expense, but they are not the only one. Lost wages, evaluation costs, and reunification services compound the financial loss — pushing most families toward pro se representation once their savings run out.

Expense Category	Responses	Median	Mean	Total Reported
Attorney Fees	22	\$11,500	\$34,564	\$760,400
Lost Wages	20	\$7,500	\$54,139	\$1,082,780
Other Court Fees	16	\$625	\$2,341	\$37,450
Therapy / Evaluations	20	\$1,350	\$5,013	\$100,259
Reunification Services	14	\$0	\$1,436	\$20,100
GAL Fees	14	\$0	\$879	\$12,300
Asset Loss ¹	16	\$60	—	—
Estimated Median Family Impact	—	\$21,035	—	—

Median vs. mean: Median is the middle reported amount, so it better reflects the typical reporting family when a few very large expenses appear. Mean is the average across reporting families and can be pulled higher by outliers.

1. On asset loss: One respondent reported an extreme outlier that skews the mean beyond usefulness. We report the median (\$60) and suppress the mean and total, pending data-quality review. Lost Wages also contains wide variance; median is the honest headline.

LOST PARENTING TIME - MONTHS

Median months lost		36	3 yrs
Mean months lost		55	4.6 yrs
Total across all families		1,157	96.4 yrs

03

WHO IS REPORTING · MONTANA

Most families documenting in Montana are currently active in, or recently closed out of, long-running cases. Nearly half have lost all contact with their children.

CASE STATUS · SYSTEM AFFECTED

CASE STATUS

Active case: stuck or delayed		14	44%
Not provided		10	31%
Case closed: more than 2 years ago		4	12%
Case closed: within last 2 years		2	6%
I am not currently in court but still affected		1	3%

SYSTEM AFFECTED

Family Court Only		15	47%
Both Family Court and CPS		11	34%
Unknown		4	12%
CPS (Child Protective Services) Only		2	6%

DURATION · CUSTODY OUTCOMES

TIME IN SYSTEM

5 – 10 years		10	31%
1 – 3 years		8	25%
Over 10 years		6	19%
3 – 5 years		3	9%
5+ years		2	6%

CUSTODY STATUS

No Contact / Total Loss of Access		13	41%
50/50 Joint		11	34%
Adopted Out (Rights Terminated)		3	9%
Visitation Only		2	6%
Children in Foster Care		1	3%

GEOGRAPHY · ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

TOP COUNTIES

Yellowstone		8	25%
Cascade		4	12%
Flathead		3	9%
Lewis And Clark		2	6%
Park		2	6%
Gallatin		1	3%

TOP ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

Other: (Short answer)		9	28%
False Accusations CPS (Non-Medical) (Vengeful ex-partner, malicious report)		6	19%
High Conflict Divorce		4	12%
Family Court False Accusations (Domestic Violence/Abuse/Alienation)		3	9%

I mark unsure because with zero evidence I was placed under a protection order based on my Ex's "feeling" of being unsafe. In every state since starting this process there is absolutely no due process for a false allegation for a

05 PARENT VOICES — MONTANA

Quotes appear as submitted. Long submissions are trimmed with [...] to fit the page; the full unedited quote is available in the online version of this report.



Made me lose everything traumatized abused and neglected

— LINDSEY

ON THE REPORTED ALLEGATIONS

Due process in family court is a fiction. Our courts are violating the Constitution of the United States and they are shielding those judgements from constitutional scrutiny by invoking state specific statutes and rules to explain their actions. Parental rights have truly been [...]

— MONTANA PARENT · CIARA

MORE VOICES FROM MONTANA

Stolen time of parent-child relationship. Deprived the ability to give or show love I can create more incentive to do better for them and yourself deprived of a chance to rebuild and strengthen the bond deprived of a sense of belonging leaving feeling more lost and unwanted or [...]

— HEATHER

They have stolen my children. My aunt is an approved kinship provider. But they won't allow her to have my kids. Because she wants me to be able to see them.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Family court has absolutely ruined my kids, their relationship with their step dad, who mind you pays all the bills and would hang the moon for them. It has never once made a motion in the best interest of the children, it has all been money moved!

— CALLIE

Make us grieve for one another

— MANDY

Sucked into a system that never had the best interest of my children and. Left with lost time never to get back.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Destroyed my family. We went in with trust and came out with lost hope and dreams

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



The system has broken apart my family. But hasn't broken me. I will continue to fight!

— SARA

It has utterly destroyed us. I left town and disappeared but I'm building my girls a homestead for their 18th birthday. They were 1 and 3 when they were stolen.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

For a year the children have been in reunification counseling with their dad. He has sat by while she decided to separate them, threaten them, deny the abuse (proven) he had towards them and tell them I am a bad mother even though he went to rehab and gave me full custody after [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The most dangerous place for a domestic violence victim is a courthouse.

— LAURA

The system falsely said that I was inappropriate with my daughter and denied my wife and I essential medical care. They used my father's false diagnosis of Alzheimer's to pin me for a mental illness because my ex wife was a nurse. They then took Alzheimer's off my father's [...]

— BRYAN

Instead of working together, lawyers and the family court has taken best friends and made us enemies. And the only one getting hurt is our daughter.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Mother has 74 failed mental health evaluations. I passed my one court ordered mental health evaluation, and my daughter was ripped from my arms.. when I had full custody mother was granted every weekend with her having full custody. I get the first and third weekend for [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Divide to conquer. Their overreach has to be stopped. They want to break the strongest bond in the world, between a mom and her kids. Its unconstitutional. It's sick.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

It has left one child disabled due to purjury and medical neglect and permanent memory loss; along with my other two children also experiencing medical and physical neglect.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



As torn me and my family apart has put a ton of pressure on my mom they've taken advantage of my Mom they're taking away my rights as a mother and I barely even get the time to call or talk to my daughter they have made every excuse in the book to keep me away from my daughter [...]

— KAYLE

Effectively torn my daughters from 4 generations of living families in mine and my ex husband's maternal side. .for political power and cult like control... Even school in Bigfork... Therapists .. I call those two .. theRAPISTS.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

19 Montana parents submitted ranked quotes. 19 appear in this report; the remainder are available at standwithmeg.com/mt.

06 HOW TO READ THIS REPORT

WHAT THIS IS

The Family Rights Registry is a national, parent-reported data collection run by Stand With Meg. Every figure in this Montana report comes from Montana respondents who voluntarily submitted survey entries about their experience inside family court and/or CPS.

This report is built to help families, advocates, reporters, and legislators see the patterns emerging in Montana — not to replace formal research, and not to name individual judges or counties as responsible parties.

WHAT IT ISN'T

This is not a representative sample. Respondents self-select. The 32 Montana families reporting here are not the universe of Montana families in court — they are the families who found the survey, trusted it enough to submit, and told us what happened to them.

Financial figures are self-reported. We flag outliers and report medians when means are distorted (see page 3, note 1). Quotes are minimally edited.

METHODOLOGY · FAMILY RIGHTS REGISTRY

Data in this report was collected April 2024 – April 2026 through standwithmeg.com/family-rights-survey. Submissions are timestamped. Duplicate-submission heuristics use normalized email + location, with direct survey rows preferred over legacy rows and the newest row retained within each source. Categorical responses from multi-select and short-answer fields are normalized monthly.

When a respondent's financial entry differs from the population by more than three standard deviations, the mean is suppressed and only the median is reported. Lost-wage, attorney-fee, and asset-loss entries are self-reported and not corroborated against tax records or court filings.

Geographic reporting uses the county field as submitted, with light normalization (e.g. "Butte silverbow" → "Butte–Silver Bow"). Quotes carry one of three public permission states: *Anonymous*, *First-name only*, or *Full attribution with consent to public use*. Court actor names appear only after 5 independent families name the same actor.

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ABOUT THIS REPORT

This report is based on self-reported survey submissions collected by Stand With Meg. Counts and categories reflect responses available at the time this packet was generated.

This report is for informational and advocacy use only, not legal advice or an official government record.

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